THE MASTERMIND COACHING CLASSES

Revision Notes

Class 6 · Social Science

Exploring Society: India and Beyond — Chapters 1 to 7 · CBSE / RBSE Syllabus

HOW TO USE THESE NOTES

Each chapter follows the textbook's own order of sections, so you can read straight through. Bold words are keywords you must be able to define. Tables compare and classify; shaded boxes hold definitions, formulas and key facts. The navy Key Takeaways box at the end of every chapter is your last-two-minutes revision.

CH.	CHAPTER TITLE	CORE THEME
1	Locating Places on the Earth	Maps, coordinates, time zones
2	Oceans and Continents	Five oceans, continents, islands, ocean–life links
3	Landforms and Life	Mountains, plateaus, plains and human life
4	Timeline and Sources of History	Measuring time, sources, early humans
5	India, That Is Bharat	Ancient names of India and their origins
6	The Beginnings of Indian Civilisation	Indus-Sarasvatī (Harappan) civilisation
7	India's Cultural Roots	Vedas, Buddhism, Jainism, folk and tribal traditions

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CHAPTER 01 · GEOGRAPHY (WITH INTRODUCTION: WHY SOCIAL SCIENCE?)

Locating Places on the Earth

This chapter shows how we find, describe and time any place on Earth: first with maps (distance, direction, symbols), then with the grid of latitudes and longitudes, and finally with local time, standard time and time zones. It is preceded by a short Introduction that explains why we study Social Science at all.

Big Questions

- What is a map and how do we use it? What are its main components?
- What are coordinates? How can latitude and longitude mark any location on Earth?
- How are local time and standard time related to longitude?

Introduction — Why Social Science?

Our age offers great possibilities (fast technological progress) and great challenges (wars, social tensions and an environment under stress). People everywhere ask how societies can live in peace and how the Earth can be protected for all species. To find answers we must first **understand the world and human societies** — this is what Social Science is about.

- It is **not** a 'science' like physics or chemistry, though it uses scientific methods where possible; human societies are too diverse for fixed procedures and fixed results.
- It has many sub-disciplines: geography, history, political science, economics, sociology, anthropology, archaeology, psychology. At the Middle Stage these are **not** separated; they are grouped into five broad themes.
- The book mixes fields on purpose (a chess game in geography, Tamil poetry, the sari, *sevā*, festivals) — this is **multidisciplinarity**. Life itself mixes many elements.
- Social Science is also the **art of asking the right questions**; hence the *Big Questions* that open every chapter.

Theme	What it covers	Chapters in Class 6
A — India and the World: Land and the People	Basics of the geographical world; how oceans, mountains and rivers shaped civilisations; India's natural setting and identity	Locating Places; Oceans and Continents; Landforms and Life; India, That Is Bharat
B — Tapestry of the Past	The past as the key to the present and a source of identity; learning from errors of rulers and governments (tapestry = a woven wall-hanging picture)	Timeline and Sources of History; Beginnings of Indian Civilisation
C — Our Cultural Heritage and Knowledge Traditions	Characteristics and guiding principles of India's rich, ancient culture	India's Cultural Roots; Unity in Diversity
D — Governance and Democracy	How the world's largest democracy works; rights and duties (dharma); organs of government; other systems	Family and Community; Grassroots Democracy (Parts 1–3)
E — Economic Life Around Us	Essentials of living; money, livelihood, resources; economic activities	The Value of Work; Economic Activities Around Us

1.1 A Map and Its Components

A **map** is a drawing of an area (a village, district, country or the world) seen from above, as if viewed from the top. An **atlas** is a collection of maps. A map works like a 'treasure guide': it shows where things are and how to reach them.

▸ Types of maps

Type	What it shows	Example
Physical map	Natural features — mountains, oceans, rivers	Physical map of India
Political map	Countries/states, boundaries, cities, capitals	India with States, UTs and capitals
Thematic map	One specific kind of information	Maps of crops, rainfall or population

▸ Three components of every map: distance, direction, symbols

Component	Meaning	Key points
Distance (scale)	Lets a huge area fit on a small sheet by shrinking real distances in a fixed ratio	1 cm = 500 m means each centimetre on the map is 500 m on the ground. On the map of India, a ruler of 2.5 cm = 500 km. Real distance = map distance × scale.
Direction	Shown by an arrow marked N pointing north	**Cardinal directions**: north (top), east, south, west (clockwise). **Intermediate**: NE, SE, SW, NW.
Symbols	Small standard pictures that stand for buildings, roads, rivers, etc., so many details fit in limited space	The **Survey of India** (government body) fixes the symbols for maps of India — e.g. railway line, metalled/unmetalled road, boundaries, river, well, tank, temple, church, mosque, post office (PO), police station (PS), trees.

> **REMEMBER**
> Different countries use different sets of symbols. Colours (for example blue for water) work like symbols too.

1.2 Mapping the Earth: Globe and Coordinates

The Earth is **nearly a sphere** (slightly flattened at the poles). A sphere cannot be shown accurately on a flat sheet — like orange peel that tears when flattened. A **globe** is a sphere with a map on it and shows the Earth's geography better than a flat map.

▸ (a) Coordinates

A pair of values that fixes a position exactly is a **system of coordinates**. Examples: a chess move noted as d2 to d4 (letter + number), or 'the 7th shop in the 5th row'. Maps use the same idea to locate any place.

▸ (b) Latitudes

- The **North Pole** and **South Pole** are the fixed points when a globe spins; the **Equator** lies halfway between them.
- **Latitude** = distance of a place from the Equator (measured in degrees). Imaginary east–west circles parallel to the Equator are **parallels of latitude**.
- Equator = **0°**; poles = **90°N** and **90°S**. The Equator is the **largest** circle; parallels shrink towards the poles (so parallels are *not* equal in length).

- **Latitude and climate:** near the Equator — hot (**torrid**); moving away — moderate (**temperate**); near the poles — cold (**frigid**).

(c) Longitudes

- **Meridians of longitude** are half-circles running from the North Pole to the South Pole; all are equal in length, each being half the length of the Equator.
- The **Prime Meridian** (0°) is the reference. It is also called the **Greenwich Meridian**, because in **1884** nations agreed to use the meridian through Greenwich (London) as the international standard.
- **Longitude** = distance from the Prime Meridian along the Equator, in degrees from 0° to 180° **East or West** (e.g. New York 74°W, Delhi 77°E, Tokyo 140°E). 180°E and 180°W are the same line, written simply 180°.
- Latitude + longitude = the two **coordinates** of a place; together the lines form the **grid** of the globe. Example: Delhi ≈ **29°N, 77°E**.
- The Prime Meridian divides the Earth into **Eastern and Western Hemispheres**; the Equator divides it into **Northern and Southern Hemispheres**.
- India lies roughly between **8°N and 37°N** latitude and **68°E and 97°E** longitude.

> **IMPORTANT**
> India had its own prime meridian long before Europe: the **madhya rekhā** ('middle line') passing through **Ujjayinī (Ujjain)**, a famous centre of astronomy where **Varāhamihira** worked about 1,500 years ago. Indian astronomers knew latitude, longitude and the need for a zero meridian. Cities near it (Kurukshetra, Rohtak, Ujjain, Maheshwar, Kanyakumari) are slightly off the line only because old timekeeping was less accurate and longitude needs accurate time.

1.3 Understanding Time Zones

- The Earth spins **west to east**, one full turn (360°) in **24 hours → 15° per hour** (360 ÷ 24). So every 15° of longitude means **1 hour** of difference.
- Moving **east** of Greenwich you **add** time (15°E = +1 hour, 30°E = +2 hours); moving **west** you **subtract** (15°W = −1 hour). If it is noon at Greenwich, it is 1 pm at 15°E and 11 am at 15°W.
- Hence measuring the **longitude of a place also tells its time**.

Term	Meaning	Example
Local time	Time worked out from the position of the Sun at a place's own longitude	Porbandar (Gujarat) and Tinsukia (Assam) are about 30° apart, so about **2 hours** apart in local time — the sun sets earlier in Assam
Standard time	One time adopted for a whole country, based on a meridian passing through it (to avoid using many local times)	**IST = GMT + 5 hours 30 minutes** (so when it is noon in London it is 5:30 pm in India)
GMT	Greenwich Mean Time — local time at the Prime Meridian	Reference for all standard times
Time zones	Zones, broadly 15° wide, that share a standard time; boundaries bend to follow country borders	Numbers on the time-zone map are hours added to or subtracted from GMT

- Very large countries use several zones: the **USA has six** and **Russia has 11** (a west-to-east traveller in Russia resets the watch 10 times).

- The **International Date Line** lies at about **180°**, opposite the Prime Meridian; the +12 and −12 zones meet there. Crossing it **eastward** you **subtract a day**; crossing **westward** you **add a day**. It bends in places so that no country is split into two different days.

1.4 Quick Reference

Likely question	Model answer
What is a map? Name its three main components.	A map is a drawing of an area as seen from above. Its components are distance (scale), direction and symbols.
What does the scale 1 cm = 500 m mean?	Each centimetre on the map represents 500 metres on the ground.
Name the four cardinal and four intermediate directions.	Cardinal: N, E, S, W. Intermediate: NE, SE, SW, NW.
Why are symbols used on maps?	To show many features in a small space; Survey of India fixes symbols for India's maps.
Define latitude and longitude.	Latitude is the distance from the Equator (0° to 90°N/S); longitude is the distance from the Prime Meridian (0° to 180°E/W).
Why is the Prime Meridian called the Greenwich Meridian?	In 1884 nations chose the meridian through Greenwich, London, as the international standard.
What was India's ancient prime meridian?	The madhya rekhā through Ujjayinī (Ujjain), used in Indian astronomical texts.
Why is it 5:30 pm in India when it is noon in London?	IST is 5 h 30 min ahead of GMT because India's standard meridian is 82.5°E (82.5 ÷ 15 = 5.5 hours).
Difference between local and standard time?	Local time depends on the longitude of a place; standard time is one common time chosen for a whole country.
What happens on crossing the International Date Line?	Going east you subtract a day; going west you add a day.
Why do the parallels of latitude differ in length?	They are circles that shrink from the Equator (largest) towards the poles.
Delhi (29°N) and Bengaluru (13°N) have the same longitude. What is their local-time difference?	None — the same longitude means the same local time; only latitude differs.

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A map shows an area from above; its components are **distance (scale), direction and symbols**.
- Latitude (0°–90°N/S from the **Equator**) and longitude (0°–180°E/W from the **Prime Meridian**) together form the **coordinates** of any place.
- Latitude shapes climate (torrid, temperate, frigid); **15° of longitude = 1 hour**.
- **IST = GMT + 5:30**; large countries have several time zones; the **International Date Line** is at about 180°.
- India's own prime meridian passed through **Ujjayinī**; Social Science is the study of people and societies and the art of asking questions.

CHAPTER 02 · GEOGRAPHY

Oceans and Continents

The Earth is the 'blue planet': about three-fourths of its surface is water and a little over one-fourth is land. This chapter maps the five oceans, the many ways of counting continents, the role of islands, and how oceans shape climate, disasters, history and our responsibilities.

Big Questions

- What are oceans and continents? What are their names and distribution?
- In what ways do oceans and continents affect life on Earth, including human life?

2.1 Water and Land on the Earth

- From space the Earth looks mostly **blue** — early astronauts called it the **blue planet**. Water covers nearly **three-fourths**; land (brown) covers a little over **one-fourth**.
- The largest water bodies are **oceans**; a large body of land is a **landmass**; a large continuous expanse of land is a **continent**.
- Oceans and continents together shape the **climate** and affect all plants, animals and humans.
- Water and land are **not equally distributed** between hemispheres: the **Northern Hemisphere has more land** than the Southern Hemisphere (seen on maps drawn from above the two poles).
- Smaller extensions of oceans have names such as **sea, bay and gulf**.

> **NOTE**
> The Indian Navy's motto *Sam noh Varunah* ('Be auspicious to us, O Varuna') invokes **Varuna**, the Vedic deity of oceans, sky and water.

▸ Salt water and fresh water

- Oceans hold most of the planet's water, but it is **salty** and unfit for most land animals, including humans.
- **Freshwater** is a very small share, found in glaciers, rivers, lakes, the atmosphere and underground (**groundwater**). This is why there is talk of a *water crisis* despite so much water; saving water at home, school and in the community matters.

2.2 The Five Oceans

Ocean	Size rank	Key points
Pacific Ocean	1st (largest)	Largest of all water bodies on Earth
Atlantic Ocean	2nd	Second largest
Indian Ocean	3rd	Bounded by Asia (north), Africa (west), Australia (east) and the Southern Ocean (south). Arabian Sea lies west of India and Bay of Bengal east of it
Southern (Antarctic) Ocean	4th	Surrounds Antarctica

Ocean	Size rank	Key points
Arctic Ocean	5th (smallest)	Around the North Pole

The five oceans are **not really separate**: the dividing lines on a map are only **conventions**. Seawater flows across oceans, and many species live in more than one.

▸ Marine life

- **Marine** = related to oceans and seas. **Flora** = plant life (tiny plants called **algae**, seaweeds). **Fauna** = animal life (fish, dolphins, whales, sharks, turtles, penguins, coral reef life and deep-sea creatures).
- Each layer, from the sunlit surface to the dark depths, has its own forms of life.

▸ Oceans and disasters

- **Clouds** formed over oceans bring rain to continents — the **monsoon rains** of India start in the ocean; without them agriculture and life would suffer.
- Oceans can also give rise to **storms** such as **cyclones** (extreme rainfall or strong winds) that damage coasts.
- A **tsunami** is a huge powerful wave usually caused by a strong **earthquake or volcanic eruption** under the sea; it can travel thousands of kilometres and flood coasts.

> **IMPORTANT**
> **26 December 2004:** an earthquake in Indonesia caused a tsunami that struck India and 13 other countries around the Indian Ocean; more than two lakh people died. In India the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and the coasts of Tamil Nadu and Kerala were badly hit. Tsunamis are rare but very destructive; many countries (including India) support the **Indian Ocean Tsunami Warning System** (an early-warning system). Handling losses of life and property is **disaster management**; India has the **National Disaster Management Authority**.

2.3 Continents

The number of continents depends on how we count — anywhere from **four to seven**. The reasons: North and South America can be seen as one landmass; Europe and Asia form one landmass (geologists call it **Eurasia**, though history and culture make them two); Africa and Eurasia can be joined as well.

Count	Continents
Four	Africa-Eurasia, America, Antarctica, Australia
Five	Africa, America, Antarctica, Australia, Eurasia
Six	Africa, Antarctica, Australia, Eurasia, North America, South America
Seven (most widely used)	Africa, Antarctica, Asia, Australia, Europe, North America, South America

- The **Olympic rings** stand for the **five inhabited continents**: Africa, America, Asia, Australia and Europe, i.e. athletes from the whole world gathering.
- On relative size (from the book's diagram): **Asia is the largest** and **Australia is the smallest** of the seven continents counted in the standard way; Africa is larger than Europe; Antarctica is larger than Australia.
- **Antarctica** — mostly ice, the coldest continent — is explored by the **Indian Antarctica Programme (since 1981)**. India's first scientific base there (1983) is **Dakshin Gangotri**; two more were built later.

About 40 Indian research teams have studied climate and environment there; the base even has a library and a post office.

2.4 Islands

- An **island** is a smaller piece of land surrounded by water on all sides; continents are also surrounded by water but are too large to be called islands. There are lakhs of islands of different sizes.
- **Greenland** is the largest island in the world — as large as the 10 biggest Indian States added together.
- India has **more than 1,300 small islands** in two major groups: **Andaman and Nicobar Islands** (Bay of Bengal) and **Lakshadweep Islands** (Arabian Sea).

2.5 Oceans and Life

- **Water cycle and rain:** oceans send rain to land; without them the Earth would be a desert.
- **Oxygen:** more than half the world's oxygen comes from the oceans' plants (hence 'the planet's **lungs**'); oceans also regulate climate.
- **Human uses:** migration, trade, military campaigns, food from fishing; coastal cultures have legends of sea gods, monsters and treasures.
- **World Oceans Day** is observed on **8 June** (UN).

Threat to the oceans	Detail
Plastic pollution	Several million tonnes of plastic enter the oceans every year and choke marine life
Other pollution	Many other forms of marine pollution caused by human activity
Overfishing	Excessive fishing reduces marine life

REMEMBER

Protecting the oceans is a **collective responsibility** for the future of the planet and humanity.

2.6 Quick Reference

Likely question	Model answer
Define continent, ocean and island.	Continent: a large continuous expanse of land. Ocean: a very large water body. Island: a smaller piece of land surrounded by water on all sides.
Why is the Earth called the blue planet?	About three-fourths of its surface is covered with water, so it looks blue from space.
Name the five oceans in decreasing order of size.	Pacific, Atlantic, Indian, Southern, Arctic.
Why are the oceans not really separate?	Water flows between them; the boundaries on maps are only conventions.
What is a tsunami and what causes it?	A huge powerful wave caused by an undersea earthquake or volcanic eruption.
Why can the number of continents be four to seven?	Because America, Eurasia and Africa–Eurasia can each be counted as one or as separate landmasses.

Likely question	Model answer
Which continents do the Olympic rings represent?	The five inhabited continents: Africa, America, Asia, Australia and Europe.
Name India's two island groups and their seas.	Andaman and Nicobar (Bay of Bengal) and Lakshadweep (Arabian Sea).
What is Dakshin Gangotri?	India's first scientific base station in Antarctica, set up in 1983.
Why are oceans called the planet's lungs?	They produce more than half the world's oxygen through marine plants.
State two ways in which humans harm oceans.	Plastic pollution and overfishing.
Which hemisphere has more land?	The Northern Hemisphere.

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Water covers about **three-fourths** of the Earth, land about one-fourth; the Northern Hemisphere has more land.
- Five oceans — **Pacific, Atlantic, Indian, Southern, Arctic** — are one connected body of water.
- Continents can be counted as **4, 5, 6 or 7**; the usual count is **seven**; **Asia** is the largest, **Australia** the smallest.
- Oceans bring **rain**, give **oxygen**, regulate **climate** and support trade and food — but also cause **cyclones and tsunamis** (e.g. 26 Dec 2004).
- Plastic pollution and overfishing threaten oceans; protecting them is a **collective responsibility** (World Oceans Day, 8 June).

CHAPTER 03 · GEOGRAPHY

Landforms and Life

Humans, like most mammals, live on land, and land looks very different from place to place. This chapter studies the three major landforms — mountains, plateaus and plains — and how each shapes climate, plants and animals, occupations, culture and the challenges people face.

Big Questions

- What are the major types of landforms, and why do they matter for life and culture?
- What challenges and opportunities of life are associated with each landform?

3.1 What is a Landform?

- A **landform** is a physical feature on the surface of the Earth. Landforms take shape over **millions of years** and are closely connected with environment and life.
- They are broadly divided into **three categories: mountains, plateaus and plains**. Each has its own climate, flora and fauna; humans have adapted to all of them, though the number of people living on each differs across the world.
- The chapter opens with a trip from **Chhota Nagpur (Jharkhand)** to **Prayagraj (Uttar Pradesh)** to **Almora (Uttarakhand)** — i.e. plateau → plain → mountains.
- **Altitude** = height of an object above sea level. **Sea level** (mean sea level) = average level of the ocean surface.

Landform	Look	Typical example
Mountain	Much higher than surroundings; broad base, steep slopes, narrow summit	Himalayas
Plateau	Raised land with a more or less flat top; some sides steep	Deccan, Tibetan
Plain	Extensive flat or gently undulating land; usually not above 300 m	Ganga plain

3.2 Mountains

▸ Features

- Recognised by a **broad base, steep slopes and a narrow summit**. Depending on height some are **snow-capped**; at lower altitudes snow melts every summer and **feeds rivers**; at great heights it never melts.
- **Hills** are lower highlands with gentler slopes and rounded tops.
- Snow and hail are **precipitation** (water from the atmosphere reaching the ground — rain, snow, hail) in solid form. Snow falls where it is cold enough, e.g. Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh.
- Mountains usually occur in **ranges**, some thousands of km long: **Himalayas (Asia), Alps (Europe), Andes (South America)**.

Peak	Where / note
Mount Everest	Between Tibet (China) and Nepal; highest in the world at 8,848 m. Tibetans: *Chomolungma* ('Mother Goddess of the World'); Nepalis: *Sagarmatha* ('Goddess of the Sky')

Peak	Where / note
Kanchenjunga	Between Nepal and Sikkim; one of the two highest peaks of the Himalayan range (with Everest)
Aconcagua	Highest peak of the Andes, South America
Kilimanjaro	Eastern Africa; an isolated mountain, not part of any range
Mont Blanc	Highest mountain of the Alps, Western Europe
Anamudi (Anai Peak)	Kerala; highest mountain in south India

IMPORTANT

Young vs old mountains: tall, sharp-peaked mountains like the **Himalayas** are relatively *young* (formed recently in Earth's history, still millions of years ago) and are **still rising**. Shorter, rounded mountains like the **Aravalli Range** are much *older*, rounded by **erosion**.

▸ Mountain environment

- Slopes carry **montane forest** with **conifers** — pine, fir, spruce, deodar — tall, cone-shaped, with thin pointed leaves. Higher up they give way to **grasses, moss and lichen**.
- Fauna: golden eagle, peregrine falcon, Canadian lynx, snow leopard, ibex, Himalayan tahr, mountain hare, yak, grey fox, black bear.
- **Kālidāsa's *Kumārasambhava*** (at least 1,500 years ago) opens by praising the Himalaya as 'Lord of mountains' stretching from the western to the eastern ocean, with winds carrying spray of the descending Gangā and shaking deodar trees.
- The **Ganga** (~2,500 km long) rises in the Himalayas. Tributaries: **Yamuna and Ghagara** (also Himalayan) and **Son** (from the Vindhya Range to the south).

▸ Life in the mountains

Aspect	Details
Terrain	Rugged, steep; regular farming only in some valleys
Farming	**Terrace farming** — cutting steps into slopes
Occupations	**Herding** preferred over agriculture in many regions; **tourism** (scenery, air, skiing, hiking, mountaineering, paragliding, pilgrimage)
Challenges	Landslides, avalanches, cloudbursts, flash floods, heavy snowfall, cold; uncontrolled tourism straining the fragile environment
Culture	Mountains regarded as sacred, e.g. Everest, **Mount Kailash** (Tibet) holy to Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and followers of Bon

Terms: *valley* — lower area between hills with a stream or river; *landslide* — sudden collapse of earth or rock; *avalanche* — sudden fall of snow, ice or rocks; *cloudburst* — sudden violent rainstorm; *flash flood* — sudden local flood, often after a cloudburst.

> **NOTE**
> **Bachendri Pal** — first Indian woman on Mount Everest (1984); Padma Shri 1984, Padma Bhushan 2019. **Arunima Sinha** lost a leg at 22, climbed Everest in 2013 and the highest peak of every continent (incl. Vinson in Antarctica); Padma Shri 2015.

3.3 Plateaus

- A **plateau** rises above surrounding land with a more or less **flat surface**; some sides are often steep. Height varies from a few hundred metres to several thousand; plateaus can be young or old.
- **Tibetan Plateau:** largest and highest in the world; average altitude **4,500 m** ('**Roof of the World**'); ~2,500 km east to west (about Chandigarh to Kanyakumari).
- **Deccan Plateau** (central and south India): one of the oldest, formed by **volcanic activity** millions of years ago.
- **Minerals:** plateaus are 'storehouses of minerals', so **mining** is a major activity — East African Plateau (gold, diamonds); Chhota Nagpur Plateau (iron, coal, manganese).
- **Soil:** often rocky, less fertile, less suited to farming — except **lava plateaus**, which have rich **black soil**.
- **Waterfalls:** Victoria Falls (Zambezi, southern Africa), Hundru Falls (Subarnarekha, Chhota Nagpur), Jog Falls (Sharavati, Western Ghats), Nohkalikai Falls (drops 340 m from the Cherrapunji Plateau, Meghalaya).

3.4 Plains

- **Plains** are extensive flat or gently undulating lands with no large hills or deep valleys, generally **not more than 300 m above sea level**.
- **Floodplains** form where rivers from mountains deposit **sediments** (rock particles, sand, silt), making soil **very fertile** — ideal for crops. Plains support varied flora and fauna.
- **Life in plains:** the first civilisations grew around rivers in fertile plains; a large part of the world's population still lives on plains. About **40 crore** people (over one-fourth of India's population) live in the **Ganga plain**.
- **Occupations:** river fishing and agriculture. Food crops — rice, wheat, maize, barley, millets; fibre crops — cotton, jute, hemp.
- **Irrigation:** traditionally rainfed; now canals and groundwater pumping. This raised production but **depleted groundwater**. Other problems: high population and pollution.
- **Rivers and culture:** river sources and **confluences** (meeting points of rivers) are sacred; festivals and rituals are held there. Gentle slopes make **navigation** easy, supporting trade and travel (boats still used on stretches of the Ganga).

3.5 Other Landforms and Tiṇais

- **Deserts** are large dry expanses with very little precipitation and unique flora and fauna. **Hot:** Sahara (Africa), Thar (north-west Indian subcontinent). **Cold:** Gobi (Asia). Some call Antarctica a desert. Thar communities have rich folk songs and legends.
- Human survival in every landform shows our **adaptability and resilience** (capacity to meet and overcome challenges).

The ancient Tamil **Sangam** poetry's five **tiṇais** are a different classification of landscapes, tied to deities, lifestyles and emotions (concepts matter more than names):

Tiṇai	Landscape	Main occupation
Kuriñji	Mountainous regions	Hunting and gathering
Mullai	Grassland and forests	Cattle rearing
Marudam	Fertile agricultural plains	Farming
Neydal	Coastal regions	Fishing and seafaring
Pālai	Arid, desert-like regions	Journeying and fighting

3.6 Comparison and Quick Reference

Feature	Mountains	Plateaus	Plains
Surface	Steep, narrow summit	Flat top, steep sides	Flat / gently undulating
Height	Far above surroundings	Hundreds to thousands of m	Under ~300 m
Soil / resources	Forests, rivers from snow	Minerals; rocky soil (lava: black)	Fertile alluvial soil
Main activities	Terrace farming, herding, tourism	Mining	Agriculture, fishing, trade
Challenges	Landslides, avalanches, floods	Less fertile soil	Population, pollution, groundwater loss

Likely question	Model answer
What is a landform? Name the three major types.	A physical feature of the Earth's surface formed over millions of years; mountains, plateaus and plains.
How do mountains differ from hills?	Mountains are much higher with steep slopes and narrow summits; hills are lower with gentler slopes and rounded tops.
Why are the Himalayas called young mountains?	They formed recently in geological time, have sharp peaks and are still rising, unlike the old, eroded Aravalli.
What is terrace farming and why is it used?	Cutting steps into mountain slopes to cultivate, because flat land is scarce.
Why is the Tibetan Plateau called the Roof of the World?	It is the highest plateau, with an average altitude of about 4,500 m.
Why are plateaus called storehouses of minerals?	They hold large deposits of iron, coal, manganese, gold, diamonds, etc., so mining is major there.
Why are river plains fertile?	Rivers deposit sediments — rock particles, sand and silt — enriching the soil.
What problems has irrigation brought to the Ganga plain?	Groundwater depletion; along with high population and pollution.
Name two mountain hazards.	Landslides, avalanches (also cloudbursts, flash floods).

Likely question	Model answer
Why are river confluences important culturally?	They are considered sacred and hosts of festivals and rituals.
Name one hot and one cold desert.	Sahara or Thar (hot); Gobi (cold).
Match tiṇai Neydal.	Coastal region — fishing and seafaring.

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Landforms are **mountains, plateaus and plains**; each has distinct climate, life and activities.
- Himalayas are **young and growing**; Aravalli and Deccan are **old**; Tibetan Plateau is the **highest**.
- Mountains: terraces, herding, tourism, hazards; plateaus: **minerals** and waterfalls; plains: **fertile farming** and early civilisations.
- Rivers and landforms are woven into **culture** — sacred peaks, confluences, the Sangam **tiṇais**.
- Every landform brings both **challenges and opportunities**; humans show remarkable adaptability.

CHAPTER 04 · HISTORY

Timeline and Sources of History

History is the study of the human past. This chapter explains how historians measure time (eras, BCE/CE, centuries, millenniums, timelines), what sources they use to rebuild the past, and how early humans moved from hunting and gathering to farming and village life.

Big Questions

- How do we measure historical time?
- How can various sources help us understand history?
- How did early humans live?

4.1 How Do We Learn About the Past?

- **History** = the study of the human past. E.H. Carr called it 'an unending dialogue between the present and the past'; we understand the present in the light of the past.
- The Earth is about **4.54 billion years** old; humans occupy only a tiny, most recent part of its long history.
- Museums (e.g. the National Museum, New Delhi) preserve statues, coins and ornaments that help us understand history.

Expert	What they study
Geologists	Physical features of the Earth — soil, stones, hills, mountains, rivers, seas, oceans
Palaeontologists	Remains of plants, animals and humans from millions of years ago, as **fossils**
Anthropologists	Human societies and cultures from the oldest times to the present
Archaeologists	Past by digging up remains: tools, pots, beads, figurines, toys, bones and teeth, burnt grains, parts of houses, bricks
Epigraphists	Ancient inscriptions
Historians	Study and write about the past, using all of the above

DEFINITION

Fossils — impressions of footprints, or parts of plants or animals, found preserved within layers of soil or rocks.

4.2 How Is Time Measured in History?

- Every society has had its own way of measuring time; major events (birth of an important person, start of a king's reign) often began a new **era** (a distinct period of time).
- Today the **Gregorian calendar** is used worldwide: 12 months, 365 days, a **leap year every four years**; century years (1800, 1900, 2000) are leap years only if divisible by 400 — so only 2000 was a leap year of those three.
- Hindu, Muslim, Jewish, Chinese and other calendars are used side by side for festivals and auspicious events.

- The conventional year of **Jesus Christ's birth** is the starting point. Years after it: **AD → now CE (Common Era)**. Years before it: **BC → now BCE (Before Common Era)**, counted backwards.
- Examples: independence 1947 CE (or AD 1947); Buddha born about **560 BCE**.

> **IMPORTANT**
> **There is no year zero** — 1 CE follows 1 BCE directly. To find years between a BCE and a CE date, **add them and subtract 1**. 2 BCE to 2 CE = 2 + 2 − 1 = **3** years. Buddha's birth to 2024 CE: 560 + 2024 − 1 = **2,583** years. Between two BCE dates (or two CE dates) simply subtract.

▸ Timeline

A **timeline** marks a sequence of dates and events for a period and shows the **order** in which events happened (e.g. the Buddha, 560 BCE, came before Jesus). The book's long timeline uses a dotted portion to skip periods (otherwise it would be almost 3 m long).

Approx. date	Event on the timeline
300,000 BCE	Modern humans (*Homo sapiens*) appear
40,000 BCE	First rock art in the world (as marked)
14,000 BCE	Ice Age (as marked); last Ice Age ended about 12,000 years ago
Around 10,000 BCE and after	First settlements and the beginning of agriculture
About 8000 BCE	Beginning of copper metallurgy (as marked)
About 4000 BCE	Pottery technology in the Indian Subcontinent; first cities in Mesopotamia (as marked)
~2000 BCE onwards	Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation (as marked on the chart)
560 BCE	Birth of the Buddha
3rd century BCE	Aśhoka
1 CE	Conventional birth of Jesus Christ

> **NOTE**
> The exact placement of some items on Fig. 4.3 is read from a diagram; use the textbook figure for exact dates.

▸ Longer durations

Term	Meaning	Examples
Decade	10 years	—
Century	100 years; counted from 1 CE. CE centuries: 1st = 1–100 CE	21st century CE = 2001 to 2100; 3rd century BCE = 300 to 201 BCE
Millennium (plural: millenniums / millennia)	1,000 years; counted from 1 CE or 1 BCE	We are in the 3rd millennium CE (2001–3000); 1st millennium BCE = 1000 BCE to 1 BCE

> **REMEMBER**
> To find the century of a CE year, take the hundreds and add 1: 1828 → 19th century; 320 CE → 4th century CE. (Rani of Jhansi, born 1828, was 19th century; independence in 1947 is 119 years after 1828.)

Pañchāṅga — traditional Indian calendar book of tables listing days of each month with astronomical data (sun and moon positions): predicts eclipses, sunrise and sunset, often weather, festival dates and timings; still widely used.

4.3 What Are the Sources of History?

A **source of history** is a place, person, text or object from which we gather information about a past event or period. Historians consult as many as possible; when sources confirm each other the 'jigsaw pieces match'; when they contradict, historians decide which to trust more — and some pieces always remain missing.

Type	Examples
Archaeological	Mounds, monuments, habitations and burials, human/animal/plant remains, tools and weapons, pottery and toys, ornaments and figurines, coins, structures, copper plates, inscriptions
Literary	Vedas and Itihāsas, folklore, genealogical (family-line) texts, poems and plays, manuscripts, historical texts and chronicles, scientific and technological texts, travelogues, collections of stories
Artistic	Sculptures, paintings, panels
Oral	Folklore and traditions passed on by speech; memories of relatives
Foreign accounts	Travelogues and writings by travellers from other lands
Modern	Newspapers (recent two or three centuries), electronic media (TV, internet)

- Many people contribute: historians, archaeologists, epigraphists, anthropologists, experts in literature and languages.
- In the last ~50 years **scientific studies** help more and more: ancient climates, chemical analysis of excavated materials, **genetics** (how features pass from one generation to the next) of ancient people.
- Family history sources: photographs, diaries, ID cards, memories of relatives.

4.4 The Beginnings of Human History

- Modern humans (*Homo sapiens*) have walked the Earth for about **300,000 years** — still a tiny fraction of Earth's history.
- **Early life:** lived in **bands/groups** for mutual help, in temporary camps, **rock shelters or caves**; constantly sought food and shelter; were **hunters and gatherers**; had beliefs about natural elements and possibly some notion of an **afterlife**; spoke languages now lost.
- **Technology:** used **fire**; made improved stone axes, blades, arrowheads and other tools.
- **Art:** rock paintings in hundreds of caves worldwide — simple figures and symbols, or detailed scenes of animals and humans. Made ornaments (stone/shell beads, animal-tooth pendants) and exchanged them.
- **Ice Age:** at times Earth was very cold and much was covered with ice; when it warmed, ice melted, swelling rivers that drained into oceans. The last Ice Age lasted from over 100,000 years ago to about **12,000 years ago**.

▸ The first crops and settled life

- As living conditions improved, humans began **settling down**, **cultivating cereals and grains** and **domesticating animals** (cattle, goats).
- Communities settled **near rivers** — water plus fertile soil made farming easier — and grew in size.
- Social complexity grew: **chieftains** looked after people's welfare; **no individual ownership** of land — lands were sown and harvested collectively.
- Hamlets became villages that exchanged **food, clothing and tools**; networks of exchange grew and some villages became **small towns**.
- New technologies: **pottery** and **metals — copper first, iron later** — making durable tools, daily-use objects and ornaments.
- This stage prepared the way for **civilisation** (Chapter 6).
- Gender roles shown in pictures may not be accurate: women may have painted or prepared colours, men may have cooked or cared for children — we have limited information.

4.5 Quick Reference

Likely question	Model answer
What is history?	The study of the human past.
Distinguish geologists, palaeontologists, anthropologists and archaeologists.	Geologists study Earth's physical features; palaeontologists study fossils; anthropologists study human societies and cultures; archaeologists dig up remains such as tools, pots and bones.
What do BCE and CE mean?	Before Common Era (years before the conventional birth of Jesus, counted backwards) and Common Era (years after it, formerly AD).
Why do we add and subtract 1 when finding years between BCE and CE?	Because there is no year zero; 1 CE directly follows 1 BCE.
How many years ago was the Buddha born (560 BCE) if the year is 2024 CE?	560 + 2024 − 1 = 2,583 years.
What is a timeline and why is it useful?	A line marking dates and events in sequence; it shows the order of events and gives a picture of a period.
Define century and millennium with examples.	A century is 100 years (21st century CE: 2001–2100); a millennium is 1,000 years (3rd millennium CE: 2001–3000).
What is a pañchāṅga?	An Indian calendar book giving days, astronomical data, eclipses, sunrise/sunset, festival dates and often weather predictions.
Name the main types of sources of history.	Archaeological, literary, artistic and oral (plus foreign accounts and modern media).
Why can historians be compared to detectives?	They gather clues from many sources, compare them, resolve contradictions and rebuild the past.
How did early humans live?	As hunter-gatherers in bands, in caves/rock shelters, using fire and stone tools, making rock paintings and ornaments.
How did settled farming change human life?	More food, bigger communities near rivers, chieftains, collective land, villages and towns, pottery and metal tools.

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- History is learnt from **many sources** — archaeological, literary, artistic, oral — and from science.
- Time is measured in years, decades, **centuries and millenniums**; BCE counts backwards, CE forwards, with **no year zero**.
- A **timeline** shows the order of events.
- Early humans were **hunter-gatherers** who used fire and stone tools and made rock art.
- Farming, domestication, pottery and metals led to **villages, towns and eventually civilisation**.

CHAPTER 05 · HISTORY

India, That Is Bharat

Modern India has fixed borders, States and a known population, but the region we call the Indian Subcontinent looked very different 500, 2,000 or 5,000 years ago. This chapter traces the many names by which India has been known — those given by its own people and those given by foreigners.

Big Questions

- How do we define India?
- What were the ancient names for India?

5.1 India: Then and Now

- Today's India is a modern nation with defined borders and States, but the **Indian Subcontinent** has had many names and shifting boundaries.
- Names come to us from **ancient texts, accounts of travellers and pilgrims, and inscriptions**.
- Sri Aurobindo (chapter opening): the spiritual and cultural **unity** of India was completed very early, between the Himalayas and the two seas.
- Natural boundaries: the **Himalayas in the north** and the **oceans** (Arabian Sea, Bay of Bengal, Indian Ocean) on the other sides.

5.2 How Indians Named India

Source / name	Meaning and detail
Ṛig Veda — *Sapta Sindhava*	India's most ancient text (several thousand years old). Names the north-west region 'land of the **seven rivers**'. *Sindhava* comes from **Sindhu** (the Indus, or sometimes any river)
Mahābhārata — regional names	Lists many regions: **Kāshmīra** (Kashmir), **Kurukṣhetra** (parts of Haryana), **Vanga** (parts of Bengal), **Prāgjyotiṣha** (roughly Assam), **Kaccha** (Kutch), **Kerala**. Together they cover the whole Subcontinent
Bhāratavarṣha	Used in the Mahābhārata (written from a few centuries BCE onward). Means 'country of the **Bharatas**'. *Bharata* first appears in the Ṛig Veda for a main Vedic group; later several kings are named Bharata
Jambudvīpa	'Island of the fruit of the **jamun** (jambul / Malabar plum) tree', a tree native to India. Came to mean the whole Subcontinent. **Aśhoka** (~250 BCE) used it in an inscription for all India, which then included today's Bangladesh, Pakistan and parts of Afghanistan
Bhārata	Became the general name a few centuries later. *Viṣhṇu Purāṇa*: 'the country that lies north of the ocean and south of the snowy mountains is called Bhārata'. Written **Bharat** in the north and **Bharatam** in the south
Tamil Sangam poem (~2,000 years ago)	Praises a king known from **Cape Kumari** in the south to the **great mountain** (Himalayas) in the north and the eastern and western oceans — a similar definition

IMPORTANT

The **Constitution of India** (in force **1950**; studied in Grade 7) begins with 'India, that is Bharat'. The Hindi version says 'Bhārat arthāth India'.

5.3 How Foreigners Named India

Most foreign names for India come from **Sindhu** (the Indus), and passed from language to language:

People	Name for India	How it came about
Persians (Iran)	Hind, Hidu, Hindu	In the **6th century BCE** a Persian emperor conquered the Indus region (Sindhu). In ancient Persian 'Hindu' was a **purely geographical** term, not a religion
Greeks	Indoi / Indike	From the Persian sources; they dropped the initial 'h' because Greek had no such letter. (Sindhu → Hindhu → Indoi/Indike)
Chinese	Yintu / Yindu; also Tianzhu	Sindhu → Hindhu → Indu → Yindu. *Tianzhu* could mean 'heavenly master', showing respect for India as the land of the Buddha
Persian/Arabic and invaders	Hindustān	First used in a Persian inscription about **1,800 years ago**; later used by most invaders for the Subcontinent
English / French	India / Inde	Descend from the Greek and Latin forms

NOTE

Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang) travelled from China to India in the **7th century CE**, visited many places, met scholars, collected Buddhist texts, returned after **17 years** and translated the Sanskrit manuscripts into Chinese. Other Chinese scholars also visited.

Why did people travel to India? Possible motives: trade, pilgrimage and the search for Buddhist knowledge, learning from scholars, curiosity, diplomacy, conquest and the wealth of the land.

5.4 Quick Reference

Name	Used by	Basic idea
Sapta Sindhava	Ṛig Veda	Land of seven rivers (north-west)
Bhāratavarṣha	Mahābhārata	Country of the Bharatas
Jambudvīpa	Mahābhārata, Aśhoka	Island of the jamun tree
Bhārata / Bharat / Bharatam	Viṣhṇu Purāṇa, Constitution	Name used by Indians today
Hindu / Hind	Persians	Geographical, from Sindhu
Indoi / Indike	Greeks	From Persian 'Hindu'
Yindu / Tianzhu	Chinese	From Sindhu; respect for land of Buddha
Hindustān	Persian inscription, invaders	First used ~1,800 years ago

Likely question	Model answer
Why is it difficult to say when the whole Subcontinent got one name?	Ancient Indian texts are hard to date.
What does Sapta Sindhava mean?	Land of the seven rivers — the Ṛig Veda's name for the north-west region.
What is the origin of the word Sindhu?	It refers to the Indus River (or sometimes any river).
What do Bhāratavarṣha and Jambudvīpa mean?	Country of the Bharatas; island of the jamun fruit tree.
What does Aśhoka's inscription tell us?	That around 250 BCE Jambudvīpa meant the whole of India, including present Bangladesh, Pakistan and parts of Afghanistan.
How does the Viṣhṇu Purāṇa define Bhārata?	As the country north of the ocean and south of the snowy mountains.
How is the name written in north and south India?	Bharat in the north, Bharatam in the south.
How did the name 'India' originate?	Sindhu → Persian Hindu → Greek Indoi/Indike → Latin → English India.
Did 'Hindu' in ancient Persian mean a religion?	No — it was purely geographical, meaning the land of the Indus.
Who was Xuanzang?	A Chinese scholar-pilgrim who came to India in the 7th century CE, stayed 17 years and carried Buddhist texts to China.
What phrase does the Constitution use for the country?	'India, that is Bharat' (Hindi: 'Bhārat arthāth India').
Why did the Chinese use 'Tianzhu'?	It could be read as 'heavenly master', reflecting respect for India as the land of the Buddha.

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- India has had **many names** in its long history, recorded in texts, inscriptions and travellers' accounts.
- Indians used **Sapta Sindhava, Jambudvīpa, Bhāratavarṣha and Bhārata**; **Bhārata** is the name in most Indian languages today.
- Foreigners — Persians, Greeks, Chinese — derived names from **Sindhu**, giving **Hindu, Indoi, Yindu** and finally **India**.
- Ancient Indians and foreigners alike saw India as the land between the **Himalayas and the seas**.
- The Constitution joins both names: **'India, that is Bharat'**.

CHAPTER 06 · HISTORY

The Beginnings of Indian Civilisation

After early farming villages came civilisation. This chapter defines 'civilisation' and studies the earliest one in the Indian Subcontinent — the Harappan, Indus or Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation — its planned cities, water management, farming, trade, crafts, art and eventual decline.

Big Questions

- What is a civilisation?
- What was the earliest civilisation of the Indian Subcontinent?
- What were its major achievements?

6.1 What Is a Civilisation?

'Civilisation' means an advanced stage of human society. Here it must have at least these characteristics:

Characteristic	Why it matters
Government and administration	To manage a complex society and its many activities
Urbanism	Town-planning, growth of cities and their management, water management and drainage
Variety of crafts	Managing raw materials (stone, metal) and producing finished goods (ornaments, tools)
Trade — internal and external	To exchange goods within a city or region and with distant regions
Some form of writing	To keep records and communicate
Cultural ideas	About life and the world, expressed through art, architecture, literature, oral traditions, customs
Productive agriculture	Enough to feed not just villages but cities

- Civilisation began at different times in different places: **Mesopotamia** (modern Iraq and Syria) about **6,000 years ago**; **Egypt** a few centuries later; the Indian story begins in the **north-west** of the Subcontinent.
- Timeline: Mesopotamian beginning ~4000 BCE; Egyptian a bit later; **Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation about 2600 to 1900 BCE** (mature phase).

6.2 From Village to City

- The plains of **Punjab** and **Sindh** are watered by the **Indus and its tributaries** — fertile and good for farming. A **tributary** is a river flowing into a larger river.
- A few millenniums ago the **Sarasvatī River** flowed from the Himalayan foothills through Haryana, Punjab, parts of Rajasthan and Gujarat.
- From about **3500 BCE** villages grew into towns; around **2600 BCE** towns became **cities** — called the **First Urbanisation of India**.

- **Names:** Indus, Harappan, Indus-Sarasvatī or Sindhu-Sarasvatī civilisation; people are **Harappans**. It is one of the world's oldest civilisations.
- **Why 'Harappan'?** Harappa (now in Pakistan's Punjab) was the first city excavated, in **1920–21**; Harappa and Mohenjo-daro were identified by 1924.
- **Why not 'Indus Valley'?** The term is obsolete — the civilisation extended well beyond the Indus region.

City	Modern location
Harappa	Punjab (Pakistan)
Mohenjo-daro	Sindh (Pakistan)
Ganweriwala	Cholistan desert, Pakistan
Dholavira	Rann of Kutch, Gujarat
Lothal	Gujarat (dockyard)
Rakhigarhi	Haryana
Kalibangan	Rajasthan
Farmana, Bhirrana, Banawali	Haryana (smaller sites / towns)

▸ The Sarasvatī River

- Today called **Ghaggar** in India and **Hakra** in Pakistan (Ghaggar-Hakra); now **seasonal**, flowing only in the rains.
- Mentioned in the **Ṛig Veda** as goddess and river flowing 'from the mountain to the sea'; later texts say it dried up.
- Its basin has a high density of sites — two major cities (Rakhigarhi, Ganweriwala), smaller ones and towns.

6.3 Town-Planning and Water Management

- Larger cities were built to **precise plans**: wide streets, often aligned to cardinal directions; **fortifications**; two parts — **upper town** (elite: rulers, officials, administrators, priests) and **lower town** (common people). **Dholavira had three zones**, and used stone foundations.
- Large buildings such as **warehouses** for collective use; houses of all sizes along streets and lanes with the **same quality of construction**; buildings generally of **bricks**.
- **Great Bath, Mohenjo-daro:** ~12 × 7 m tank, waterproofed with **natural bitumen** over carefully laid bricks; small rooms around, a well, a drain to empty it. Purpose debated: public bath (ruled out because most houses had bathrooms), bath for royalty, or ritual use.
- **Drainage:** bathing areas in homes connected to covered drains below streets (e.g. Lothal). **Wells:** hundreds in Mohenjo-daro (about 700 counted); other places used ponds, streams, reservoirs.
- **Dholavira:** at least six large reservoirs cut in rock or built of stone, linked by underground drains for water harvesting; largest reservoir about 73 m long. This implies organised labour, a ruler and municipal authority.

6.4 Food, Farming and Trade

Area	Details
Crops	Barley, wheat, some millets, sometimes rice; pulses and vegetables. **First in Eurasia to grow cotton**
Tools	Farm tools including the **plough** (clay model from Banawali)
Animals / fish	Domesticated animals for meat; fishing in rivers and sea (bones found)
Diet evidence	Dairy products; also turmeric, ginger, banana traces in cooking pots
Exports	Ornaments, timber, objects of daily use, probably gold, cotton and some food
Imports	Probably copper (scarce at home)
Ornaments	Beads of **carnelian** (reddish semi-precious stone from Gujarat) with special drilling techniques; **conch-shell bangles**
Metals	Copper; **bronze** (copper + tin) for tools, pots, pans, figurines
Routes	Land, rivers and sea — the first intensive **maritime activity** in India; coastal settlements in Gujarat and Sindh
Lothal dockyard	Basin 217 m × 36 m (a little over two football grounds long)
Seals	Thousands of small **steatite** seals with animals (unicorn, bull, horned tiger) and writing signs; used to identify goods and traders. **The script remains undeciphered**

> **NOTE**
> Trade evidence abroad: Harappan carnelian beads at **Susa (Iran)** and an ivory comb on the coast of **Oman**.

6.5 The Lives of the Ancients

- **Daily objects:** bronze mirror, terracotta pots, stone weights, bronze chisel, games board, terracotta whistle (toys and games for adults and children).
- **Cultural objects:** bronze **'Dancing Girl'** (10.8 cm, bangles covering an arm); so-called 'Priest King' statuette; terracotta figure seated in a *namaste*; **swastika** seal; seal of a three-faced deity on a platform with animals; a Lothal pot design that seems to show the story of the **thirsty crow**.

6.6 The End or a New Beginning?

- Around **1900 BCE** the cities were abandoned one by one; people dispersed to hundreds or thousands of small rural settlements; the old administration disappeared.
- Earlier theory of invasion or warfare is not supported — **no trace of warfare**, no army or weapons found; a relatively **peaceful** civilisation.
- **Agreed causes:** (1) a worldwide **climate change from 2200 BCE** — less rain, drier phase, harder farming; (2) the **Sarasvatī dried up** in its central basin, so Kalibangan and Banawali were abandoned.
- Cities disappeared but much of the culture and technology **survived** into the next phase of Indian civilisation.

- B.B. Lal: Harappan society was one of 'mutual accommodation', not exploitation, with no glaring rich–poor gap.

6.7 Quick Reference

Likely question	Model answer
What is a civilisation? List four characteristics.	An advanced stage of society; government, urbanism, crafts, trade, writing, cultural ideas, productive agriculture.
Why is it called Harappan civilisation?	Harappa was the first city excavated (1920–21).
Why is 'Indus Valley' no longer used?	Sites lie far beyond the Indus region, including the Sarasvatī basin, Gujarat and Haryana.
When did the Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation flourish?	About 2600 to 1900 BCE, with village growth from 3500 BCE.
Describe Harappan town-planning.	Planned, fortified cities with wide streets, upper and lower towns, brick buildings, warehouses and drains.
What was the Great Bath?	A waterproofed tank (~12 × 7 m) at Mohenjo-daro, probably used for ritual; its exact purpose is debated.
How did Harappans manage water?	Wells, drains, reservoirs; Dholavira's rock-cut reservoirs and underground drains.
What did the Harappans grow and eat?	Wheat, barley, millets, some rice, pulses, vegetables, cotton; dairy, meat and fish; also turmeric, ginger and banana.
Why was Lothal important?	It had a huge dockyard (217 × 36 m) for sea trade.
What were seals used for?	Identifying goods and traders; they bear animal figures and undeciphered writing.
What caused the decline?	Climate change (drier from 2200 BCE) and the drying of the Sarasvatī River.
Why do we think it was peaceful?	No evidence of warfare, armies or weapons.

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A civilisation needs **government, cities, crafts, trade, writing, culture and surplus farming**.
- The **Indus-Sarasvatī (Harappan) civilisation (~2600–1900 BCE)** was India's first urbanisation, spread across present India and Pakistan.
- Planned cities, **water management**, cotton, bronze, bead-making, seals and **maritime trade** were its signature achievements.
- Its script is **undeciphered**; it appears peaceful and egalitarian.
- **Climate change and the drying of the Sarasvatī** led to its decline, but its culture lived on.

CHAPTER 07 · HISTORY

India's Cultural Roots

Indian culture is like an ancient tree: many roots nourish a common trunk from which many branches (art, literature, science, medicine, religion, governance and 'schools of thought') grow. This chapter studies the Vedas and Vedic culture, the Upaniṣhads, the rise of Buddhism and Jainism, and the contribution of folk and tribal traditions.

Big Questions

- What are the Vedas? What is their message?
- What new schools of thought emerged in India in the 1st millennium BCE? What are their core principles?
- What is the contribution of folk and tribal traditions to Indian culture?

7.1 The Tree of Indian Culture

- Indian culture is several millenniums old; some roots go back to the **Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation**.
- A **school of thought** = a group of thinkers or spiritual seekers who share similar ideas about human life and the world. Hundreds emerged over time.
- **Spiritual** = concerned with the spirit or soul (*ātman*); **seeker** = one who seeks truth (sage, saint, yogi, philosopher).
- The text avoids calling Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism just 'religions' because each has philosophical, spiritual, religious, ethical and social aspects; 'religion' is too limiting.

7.2 The Vedas and Vedic Culture

▸ What are the Vedas?

- *Veda* comes from Sanskrit **vid** = knowledge (cf. *vidyā*). There are **four Vedas**: **Ṛig Veda, Yajur Veda, Sāma Veda, Atharva Veda** — India's most ancient texts and among the oldest in the world.
- They contain thousands of **hymns** (prayers as poems and songs), **recited orally**, composed in the **Sapta Sindhava** region. The Ṛig Veda is the oldest; scholars place it between the **5th and 2nd millennium BCE**.
- Memorised through rigorous training for **100–200 generations** and passed on almost unchanged. In **2008 UNESCO** recognised Vedic chanting as a 'masterpiece of the oral and intangible heritage of humanity'.
- Hymns were composed by **rishis** (male seers) and **rishikas** (female seers) in early Sanskrit, addressed to deities such as **Indra, Agni, Varuṇa, Mitra, Sarasvatī, Uṣhas**.
- Deities with the seers sustained **ṛitam** — truth and order in human life and the **cosmos**.
- *Ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti* — 'The Existent is one, but sages give it many names' (the gods are one reality).
- Key values: **Truth** (often another name for God). The last mantras of the Ṛig Veda call for **unity**: 'Come together, speak together; common be your mind'
- **Rituals (yajña):** offerings and prayers to deities, daily ones to **Agni** (fire), becoming more complex over time.

▸ Vedic society

- Organised in **janas** (clans); the Ṛig Veda lists over 30 — **Bharatas, Purus, Kurus, Yadus, Turvaśhas** — each linked with a region of the north-west.
- Clues about governance: **rājā** (king), **sabhā** and **samiti** (assemblies).
- Professions: agriculturist, weaver, potter, builder, carpenter, healer, dancer, barber, priest.

▸ Vedic schools of thought

- The **Upaniṣhads** built on the Vedas and introduced **rebirth** and **karma** (actions and their results).
- **Vedanta:** everything — human life, nature, universe — is one divine essence, **brahman** (not the god Brahmā), sometimes called **tat** ('that'). Mantras: *aham brahmāsmi* ('I am brahman') and *tat tvam asi* ('You are That').
- **Ātman** (Self) — divine essence in every being, ultimately one with brahman; so all things are connected. Prayer: *sarve bhavantu sukhinah* — 'May all creatures be happy'.
- **Yoga** (early 1st millennium BCE) developed methods to realise brahman in one's consciousness. Vedanta, Yoga and others form the foundations of what is today called **Hinduism**.

Upaniṣhad story	Message
Śhvetaketu and Uddālaka (Chhāndogya)	Proud after 12 years in a gurukula, he cannot answer his father. The father explains brahman using the seed of the banyan fruit and clay pots: all things emerge from one essence — 'You are That'
Nachiketa and Yama (Katha)	Given to Yama (god of death) by an angry father; persists in asking what happens after death. Yama teaches the ātman is hidden in all, neither born nor dies
Gārgī and Yājñavalkya (Bṛihadāraṇyaka)	At King Janaka's debate the rishika Gārgī questions the rishi Yājñavalkya on the nature of the world and brahman; resumes later and gets the explanation. Questioning is valued, by women, men and children

7.3 Buddhism

Schools that did not accept the authority of the Vedas also emerged. Buddhism is one.

- **Siddhārtha Gautama** born about two-and-a-half millenniums ago (taken as **560 BCE**) in **Lumbini** (today Nepal) into a royal family; grew up protected in a palace.
- At **29** he saw an old man, a sick man, a dead body and a happy, peaceful **ascetic**; he left home, wife and son.
- After meditating under a **pipal tree at Bodh Gaya (Bihar)** he attained **enlightenment**: **avidyā (ignorance) and attachment** cause suffering; he devised a method to remove them. He became the **Buddha** ('enlightened/awakened one').
- Teachings: **ahimsa** (non-hurting; includes thought), inner discipline. 'Not by water is one made pure; conquering oneself is greater than conquering a thousand men on the battlefield a thousand times.'
- Founded the **Sangha** — community of **bhikṣhus** (monks) and later **bhikṣhuṇīs** (nuns). Influence spread over all Asia.
- **Jātaka tales:** stories of the Buddha's former births, e.g. the monkey-king who made his body a bridge for his troop to cross a stream, dying in the process (carved at Bharhut, Madhya Pradesh).

7.4 Jainism

- Widespread at the same time as Buddhism, though roots are said to be far older.

- **Prince Vardhamāna**, born early 6th century BCE near **Vaiśhālī (Bihar)**; left home at **30**; after **12 years** of ascetic discipline achieved supreme wisdom; known as **Mahāvīra** ('great hero').
- *Jain* from **jina** = 'conqueror' — of ignorance and attachment, not of territory.
- Core ideas: **ahimsa**, **anekāntavāda** ('not just one' view — truth has many aspects) and **aparigraha** (non-possession, limiting oneself to necessities); interdependence of all beings, even invisible organisms.
- Story of **Rohineya**, the burglar who heard a few lines of Mahāvīra's sermon, later confessed, returned the treasure and became a monk — right action and thinking and a second chance.

Monks and nuns of both faiths travelled widely, founded **monasteries** and lived in **rock-cut caves** (e.g. **Ellora, Maharashtra**, 6th–10th centuries CE, with Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves). The **Chārvāka/Lokāyata** school held only the material world exists and was not popular — showing diversity of belief.

	Vedic/Vedanta	Buddhism	Jainism
Founder / source	Vedas, Upaniṣhads	Siddhārtha Gautama (Buddha)	Mahāvīra (Vardhamāna)
Birthplace	—	Lumbini (Nepal)	Near Vaiśhālī (Bihar)
Enlightenment	Realising brahman / ātman	Bodh Gaya, under pipal tree	After 12 years of asceticism
Key ideas	Brahman, ātman, karma, rebirth	Ignorance and attachment cause suffering; ahimsa	Ahimsa, anekāntavāda, aparigraha
Order	Gurukula, rishis	Sangha (bhikṣhus / bhikṣhuṇīs)	Monks and nuns

IMPORTANT

Shared concepts: dharma, karma, rebirth, ending ignorance and suffering — the common 'trunk' of the cultural tree.

7.5 Folk and Tribal Roots

- **Oral traditions** pass on teachings without written texts; **folk traditions** come from common people, **tribal traditions** from tribes.
- A **tribe**: group of families or clans sharing common descent, culture and language, living as a close-knit community under a chief, with no private property. Ancient India had no word for tribe — they were *janas*; the Constitution says 'tribes' / **janjāti**.
- **2011:** 705 tribes, ~104 million people (more than Australia and UK together). The 19th-century idea of 'primitive' is now abandoned.
- **Shared ideas with Hinduism:** nature (mountains, rivers, trees, animals, stones) is sacred because consciousness is behind it; many deities plus belief in a higher divinity.
- Examples: **Toda** (Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu) treat over 30 peaks as divine and avoid pointing at them; **Donyipolo** (Sun and Moon) in Arunachal Pradesh; **Khandoba** in central India; **Singbonga** among Munda and Santhal.
- **Exchange both ways: Jagannath at Puri** was originally a tribal deity; mother-goddess forms; some tribes have their own versions of the **Mahābhārata and Rāmāyaṇa**.
- André Béteille: castes and tribes influenced each other's beliefs; Hinduism too has been shaped by tribal religions — **mutual enrichment**.

REMEMBER

The **banyan tree** (sacred to Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism) symbolises Indian civilisation: deep roots, massive trunk, branches that throw fresh roots.

7.6 Quick Reference

Likely question	Model answer
What does 'Veda' mean and how many Vedas are there?	Knowledge (from vid); four — Ṛig, Yajur, Sāma and Atharva.
How were the Vedas preserved?	By oral memorisation through rigorous training for 100–200 generations; UNESCO recognised Vedic chanting in 2008.
What is ṛitam?	Truth and order in human life and the cosmos, sustained by the deities and seers.
Explain 'Ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti'.	The supreme reality is one; sages call it by many names.
What were janas, sabhā and samiti?	Clans of Vedic society; assemblies that were part of governance.
What new ideas did the Upaniṣhads introduce?	Rebirth, karma, brahman and ātman, and the oneness of all.
Who was Nachiketa?	A boy who sought Yama's teaching about death and learned that the ātman is immortal.
How did Siddhārtha become the Buddha?	After seeing old age, sickness and death, he left the palace and attained enlightenment at Bodh Gaya, learning ignorance and attachment cause suffering.
What are the three key teachings of Jainism?	Ahimsa, anekāntavāda and aparigraha.
What does ahimsa mean?	Non-hurting — avoiding violence in action and in thought.
Why is 'religion' avoided for these traditions?	They have philosophical, spiritual, ethical and social aspects as well; religion is too limiting.
Give examples of exchange between tribal and mainstream traditions.	Jagannath of Puri from a tribal deity; tribes with their own Mahābhārata and Rāmāyaṇa.

★ **KEY TAKEAWAYS**

- The **Vedas** are India's oldest texts, orally preserved; their message is the **unity of truth** and of people.
- The **Upaniṣhads** introduced **brahman, ātman, karma and rebirth**; Vedanta and Yoga became foundations of Hinduism.
- **Buddhism** and **Jainism** questioned Vedic authority and stressed **ahimsa**, discipline and conquering ignorance and attachment.
- All shared **dharma, karma, rebirth** and the search to end suffering.
- **Folk and tribal traditions** treat nature as sacred and have exchanged ideas freely with other traditions — mutual enrichment.